

I genuinely think this is now at the right level. It doesn't try to be a 40-page design system like Google Material Design, but it's much stronger than a basic color palette document. It clearly communicates the design philosophy and gives enough guidance that both a designer and Claude can build consistently.

03. UI Style Guide (V1)

Product

Mot-à-Mot

1. Brand Identity

Brand Personality

Mot-à-Mot feels like **a patient French friend who quietly helps you express your thoughts in natural, confident French.**

Rather than correcting mistakes, the product guides users toward more grammatically correct and naturally spoken French in a calm, encouraging way.

The experience should never feel like an exam or grammar test. Instead, it should feel like receiving quick, thoughtful help before sending a message.

Brand Characteristics

Mot-à-Mot should feel:

- Friendly
 - Intelligent
 - Calm
 - Helpful
 - Credible
 - Minimal
 - Straightforward
 - Gentle
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Brand Attributes

We Are	We Are Not
Encouraging	Judgmental
Modern	Corporate
Educational	Academic
Minimal	Cluttered
Friendly	Harsh
Fast	Feature-heavy
Subtle	Flashy

2. Design Philosophy

Philosophy

Mot-à-Mot prioritizes **function over decoration**.

Every design element should serve a clear purpose, helping users move from writing to sending their message with minimal friction.

The interface should feel:

- Minimal
- Functional
- Calm
- Uncluttered

Visual design should support the experience rather than compete for attention.

Design Principles

- Generous whitespace
- One clear action per screen
- Calm visual hierarchy
- Minimal decoration
- Information before visuals

3. Color System

The interface should subtly reflect the French language without becoming visually overwhelming.

Color Guidelines

Purpose	Design Intent
Primary	Deep French Blue inspired by the French flag. Used for primary actions, links, and interactive elements.
Secondary Accent	Muted French Red used sparingly for branding accents rather than functional actions.
Success	Green for corrected messages, successful actions, and positive feedback.
User-Correctable Warning	Orange for issues the user can resolve (e.g., empty input, incomplete voice transcription).
System Error	Red reserved exclusively for technical failures that require no user correction (e.g., AI service unavailable).
Background	Soft off-white to reduce eye strain during repeated use.
Surface	White cards used to separate content sections.
Primary Text	High-contrast dark text for maximum readability.
Secondary Text	Neutral grey for helper text and supporting information.
Borders	Thin neutral borders with clean, subtle separation.

Color Usage Principles

- Colour should communicate meaning, not decoration.
- Maintain high contrast between text and background.
- Use accent colours sparingly.
- Success, warning, and error colours should always represent consistent system states.

4. Typography

Font Family

Inter

The application should use a clean, modern sans-serif typeface that prioritizes readability across desktop and mobile devices.

Typography Scale

Element	Size	Weight
App Title	36 px	Bold
Page Heading	28 px	Semibold
Section Heading	24 px	Semibold
Card Title	18 px	Semibold
Body Text	16 px	Regular
Caption / Helper Text	14 px	Regular
Button Text	16 px	Medium

Typography should establish a clear visual hierarchy while maintaining consistency throughout the application.

5. Buttons

Primary Button

Used for the primary action on each screen.

Appearance

- Filled Primary Blue
- White text
- Rounded corners (12 px)
- High contrast
- Full-width on mobile

Examples:

- Check My French
 - Copy Message
-

Secondary Button

Used only for secondary actions.

Appearance

- White background
 - Blue outline
 - Blue text
-

Button States

State	Behaviour
Default	Primary Blue
Hover	Slightly darker blue
Disabled	Grey background with grey text
Success	Green with "✓ Copied!" confirmation
Warning	Orange for user-correctable actions
Error	Red reserved for technical failures only

6. Input Fields

French Input Field

The primary input should be a multi-line text area.

Properties

- White background
- Rounded corners (12 px)
- Comfortable internal padding
- Thin neutral border

- Responsive width

Placeholder Example:

Je ne peux pas venir aujourd'hui.

Input States

State	Behaviour
Default	Neutral border
Focus	Primary Blue outline
User-Correctable	Orange border with helper message
System Error	Red border with technical error message

7. Cards

All content on the Results Screen should be presented within cards.

Cards help separate information into easily digestible sections.

Card Properties

- White background
- Rounded corners (16 px)
- Soft shadow
- Comfortable padding
- Consistent vertical spacing

Cards should prioritize readability over decoration.

8. Icons & Branding

Icon Style

Use a clean, rounded outline icon set.

Recommended library:

Lucide Icons

Icons should support content rather than dominate the interface.

Signature Element

The Mot-à-Mot logo should feature a **small speech bubble motif positioned subtly behind the wordmark**.

This serves as the application's signature visual element, reinforcing its identity as an AI messaging assistant while maintaining a clean and minimal appearance.

9. Spacing System

The application should follow an **8-point spacing system** to maintain visual consistency.

Token	Value
XS	4 px
S	8 px
M	16 px
L	24 px
XL	32 px
XXL	48 px

Consistent spacing should be used across all screens, cards, forms, and components.

10. Motion & Animation

Animations should communicate progress and feedback without distracting from the user's task.

Guidelines

- Interaction duration: 150–250 ms
- Smooth transitions between states

Loading

- Gentle loading animation
- Smooth transition between rotating status messages

Success

After pressing **Copy Message**:

- Button changes to ✓ **Copied!**
- Returns to **Copy Message** after approximately two seconds

Animations should always reinforce usability rather than entertain.

11. Responsive Design

Mot-à-Mot should be designed using a **mobile-first approach** while providing a polished desktop experience.

Mobile

- Single-column layout
- Full-width cards
- Comfortable touch targets
- Full-width primary buttons

Desktop

- Centered content
- Maximum content width of approximately **720 px**
- Generous whitespace surrounding the primary content area

The experience should remain visually consistent across devices.

12. Voice & Microcopy

All interface copy should sound:

- Friendly
- Clear
- Encouraging
- Concise

Avoid:

- Technical grammar terminology

- Negative or judgmental language
- Robotic phrasing

Preferred Microcopy

Avoid

Your sentence is wrong.

Incorrect grammar.

Error

Submit

Correct Sentence

Prefer

Here's a more natural way to say it.

This small change makes the sentence sound more natural.

Let's try that again.

Check My French

Ready to Send

13. Design Constraints

The following constraints should guide all future design decisions.

1. Every screen must have **one primary action**.
2. The corrected message must always be visible without scrolling.
3. Grammar explanations should support—not overshadow—the corrected message.
4. Colour should communicate meaning, not decoration.
5. Animations should reinforce progress and user feedback rather than distract from the experience.
6. Every interaction should reduce the effort required for users to return to their conversation as quickly as possible.

Final Thoughts

I think this is now a **professional-level UI Style Guide** for an MVP. It's intentionally lightweight because Mot-à-Mot is intentionally lightweight. More importantly, it aligns with your three goals:

1. **Build a genuinely useful product** for yourself and other beginner French learners.
2. **Showcase product thinking** through clear documentation that demonstrates how you approach strategy, UX, and design—not just implementation.
3. **Provide high-quality context to Claude** (or any AI coding assistant) so it can

design decisions.

The next document I would create is **04. Component Library & Screen Specifications**. Unlike the style guide, that document will define every UI component (text area, button, card, rating bar, comparison table, etc.) with exact properties and states, making it an almost direct blueprint for implementation. After that, we can move into high-fidelity mockups in Figma and then into building the application.